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This article is part of 20 Years of 30 Rock, Slate's celebration of the iconic sitcom two decades after its premiere.

In a profile of Alec Baldwin that ran in the New Yorker in 2008, two years after the premiere of *30 Rock* on NBC, writer Ian Parker described an actor at a crossroads—convinced his movie career was permanently stalled out, still angsty over his acrimonious 2002 divorce from Kim Basinger, and not totally sure what he would do with the rest of his life. Onscreen, in the show's first couple of seasons, Baldwin's network suit, Jack Donaghy, was establishing a working relationship with *TGS*'s showrunner Liz Lemon (Tina Fey), delivering backhanded compliments like "I like you. You have the boldness of a much younger woman," and burns studded with snobby, memorable turns of phrase. (After Jack's Season 1 "gentleman from Fairfield" rant, pizza will forever be "greasy peasant food" to me.) But offscreen, Baldwin was, Parker found, adrift, less like the confident Jack of earlier seasons, who baldly lies to Lemon's face about dyeing his hair, and more akin to the "unsharkulated," softer Jack Donaghy we would later see in the 2013 series finale, who mourns spending "Christmas in the Hamptons drinking Scotch and throwing firecrackers at Billy Joel's dog."

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Baldwin, it seems, initially had to be convinced to commit completely to *30 Rock*, because the role of Jack, a really good character in a really good sitcom, seemed too easy. Was it even acting for Alec Baldwin, a man with a turbulent inner life, conventionally handsome looks, and a big slabby head on a big slabby body, to play Jack, an executive passionately committed to advancing in business and in New York society who is also secretly a freak with a hidden passion for ceramic cookie jars, a hate–love relationship with his overbearing mother, and an uncanny knack for mimicry? The role of Jack depended on Baldwin's sense of comedic timing and presence in a way that his big-screen movie work in *Beetlejuice* or *The Hunt for Red October* had not. Over the next few years, Jack and Baldwin merged into the perfect symbiont, each one of them amplifying the other. The result was one of the finest performances on television—one that, even though it won Baldwin a handful of Emmys, Golden Globes, and other awards, still feels like it never got the recognition it deserved.

The Jack role, as beloved as it remains among *30 Rock* die-hards, could never be written in the activated, partisan Trump years, because Jack is a corporate, Reagan-loving Republican who is managing creatives, and sometimes reins them in and makes them insert GE microwaves into sketches, and other times is kind of, well, Daddy—a plainspoken, mean type of Daddy, doling out reality checks in Baldwin's trademark husky, pointed delivery. In a 2013 Rolling Stone postmortem on the show, co-showrunner Robert Carlock said of the character, "It's a lot more fun to let the conservative guy be right more. … It's fun to let Liz be a little less well-informed, but maybe a little more morally right, and Jack to be a lot more sophisticated." Case in point: "Where do you invest your money?" Jack asks Liz in the Season 2 episode "Rosemary's Baby," one of the show's pound-for-pound most quotable, which also gave us Jack's advice to "never go with a hippie to a second location." "I have, like, 12 grand in checking," Liz says, to which Jack replies sardonically: "Are you an immigrant?"

Often, the things Jack said were offensive, in a way that would never work for a 2026 landscape of fans habituated to demand solid red lines between heroes and villains, but felt, at the time, like just another way to draw a contrast between the New York City of Liz Lemon—creative, hapless, well-intentioned, Obama-era woke—and Jack's New York City, a world full of boldface names where the point of life is to meet famous people and make bank. In that world, Jack's developed habits of fat-shaming, age-shaming ("I'm 50. To put it in perspective that's like 32 for ladies"), and misogyny ("Don't gloat. It makes you seem mannish") are as insulting as they are ruthlessly pragmatic.

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Why doesn't all of this make Jack, a character I'd dread being trapped with at a party if he were real, too grating to watch? Because Baldwin knew how to make Jack just enough of a stock character, inches to the left of reality, that his statements don't really hurt Liz Lemon—or, by extension, me. Baldwin told Rolling Stone when the show concluded that he was inspired by Gene Hackman in *The Royal Tenenbaums*,"this kind of Hemingway manqué masculinity … a blend where you're alternately Teddy Roosevelt, and the next minute you're Dustin Hoffman in *The Graduate*: You're a neurotic mess, psychosexually, and then you're just charging up the hill with a sword in your hand." Jack is the kind of guy who spends New Year's with his famous friend, "the deep-sea explorer Bob Ballard" (classic Jack name-drop), who brings him "a 2,000-year-old amphora of wine from a sunken Phoenician trading vessel," but they end up tripping out in the backyard, high on the toxic fumes, "having vivid hallucinations of Astarte, the Phoenician goddess of sex and war." Baldwin delivered those packed-full *30 Rock* lines with a professional's aplomb, and Jack's bluster always stays just on the interesting side of unbearable. Baldwin also never feared appearing ridiculous, embracing fully those gags where he played dream versions of Harriet Tubman or Thomas Jefferson, or pulled off stereotype-shaped impressions of Tracy Jordan's parents (and young Tracy, and their Latina neighbor, and Tracy's mom's white paramour) in one of the show's most impressive displays of Baldwin's versatility.

[embedded content]

No, “Jackie D.” (as Tracy called him) wasn’t a part that just anyone could play, nor was it a part that would come around often. By the time the show was over, Baldwin had figured out that the role of Jack was a gift. “I miss that show terribly. … I’ll never have it that good again, professionally,” Baldwin wrote in “Good-Bye, Public Life,” a 2014 New York magazine essay in which he declared his intention to do only his work and participate in none of the extra parts of celebrity that involve “communicating with an audience playfully like we’re friends.” The years after this essay brought the very public debacle of the fatal shooting on the set of his movie *Rust*, and the different public debacle of his family’s unbeloved and short-lived reality show, *The Baldwins*. When all is said and done, will Jack be the role Baldwin is remembered for? I’ve got a rabbit hole of YouTube highlight reels that makes a pretty darn good case.

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